The AI Pound

FREE GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

5 AI automations UK small businesses can set up this month

Practical, low-cost ways to answer customers faster, cut admin and stay in control — explained in plain English.

For restaurants · cafés · gyms · salons · trades

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BEFORE YOU START

AI works best on the boring, repeated jobs

You don't need "an AI strategy". You need the questions you answer every day handled properly — at 9pm, on a Sunday, while you're busy with a customer.

Every automation in this guide follows three rules we use with every client:

1. Start with your most repeated task

Not the most impressive one. The one that eats the most of your week.

2. Ground the AI in your own information

Your prices, your menu, your opening hours. It should never make things up.

3. Keep a human in the loop

Anything involving money, health, complaints or emails to customers gets approved by a person first.

What you'll need

- An automation tool such as **n8n**, Make or Zapier (free or low-cost plans exist).
- An AI model account (for example OpenAI) — usually a few pounds a month at small-business volumes.
- Your existing tools: WhatsApp Business, Google Sheets, Gmail, Google Calendar, Telegram.

Costs and results vary by business and usage. The examples in this guide are designs we build and test; they're not guarantees of specific savings.

THE FIVE AUTOMATIONS

Pick one. Get it working. Then add the next.

1 Instant replies to enquiries

A WhatsApp or website assistant that answers the questions you get every day — prices, opening times, availability — using your own documents, and passes anything tricky to you.

Best for: cafés, restaurants, salons, clinics. **Watch out:** give it a clear "I'll pass this to the team" answer for anything it doesn't know.

WhatsApp Business · AI agent · Google Sheets

2 Bookings and orders you approve with one tap

Customers request a booking or order; you get it on Telegram with Approve / Decline buttons; approved ones are saved to your sheet and the customer is confirmed automatically.

Best for: takeaways, salons, trades booking site visits.

Webhook form · Telegram approval · Google Sheets

3 A voice-note personal assistant

Send a voice note: "What's on today?", "Add a task", "Email Sarah about Friday". It reads your calendar, logs tasks and drafts emails — and nothing is sent until you approve it.

Best for: owners who are always on the move.

Telegram · Speech-to-text · Gmail · Calendar

4 Lead replies: AI writes it, you approve it

When someone fills in your enquiry form, AI drafts a personal reply. You see it on your phone, tap approve or ask for changes, and it goes out from your own email.

Best for: any business where a fast, personal first reply wins the job.

Form · AI draft · Telegram approval · Gmail

5 Post once, publish everywhere

Plan your videos in a simple Google Sheet. At the scheduled time you get a preview, tap "Post it", and it goes to YouTube, Instagram, Facebook and TikTok with the right caption for each — with a built-in check for claims you shouldn't make.

Best for: businesses growing on social media without a social media manager.

Content calendar · Compliance check · 4 platforms

Your first-week checklist

- [ ] Write down the 10 questions customers ask you most.
- [ ] Put your prices, hours and FAQs in one Google Sheet or document.
- [ ] Choose **one** automation from this guide.
- [ ] Decide what the AI must always hand to a human.
- [ ] Test it with friends or staff before customers see it.
- [ ] After two weeks, look at what it answered — and improve the information it uses.

STAY SAFE AND COMPLIANT

Five rules for using AI with customers in the UK

1. Be honest that it's automated

Tell customers when they're chatting with an assistant, and how to reach a person.

2. Protect personal data (UK GDPR)

Only collect what you need, keep it secure, and say in your privacy policy which tools process it.

3. No made-up facts or reviews

Ground answers in your own information. Never use AI to write fake reviews or testimonials — it's illegal in the UK.

4. Keep humans on money, health and complaints

Use approval steps for refunds, medical questions and anything sensitive.

5. Watch your advertising claims

No guaranteed results, and no prescription-medicine claims in ads (ASA / CAP Code).

This guide is general information, not legal advice. If you're unsure, check the ICO and ASA guidance for your sector.

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WANT HELP CHOOSING?

Book a free 15-minute workflow audit

Tell us how your week runs. We'll point out the one automation that would save you the most time — no obligation, no jargon.

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